

THINK BEFORE YOU CLICK
– recognizing and
avoiding phishing
attacks

Kavya Sriram
CodeAlpha
Intern



WHAT IS PHISHING?

- A type of cyberattack where attackers pretend to be a trustworthy source to trick you into giving up sensitive info (passwords, card numbers, etc.) or clicking malicious links
- Usually arrives via email, text (smishing), or fake websites
- Goal: steal credentials, install malware, or commit fraud

HOW TO RECOGNIZE A PHISHING EMAIL

- Mismatched sender address – looks legit at a glance, but the actual email domain is off (e.g. support@paypal.com instead of paypal.com)
- Urgency/fear tactics – "Your account will be suspended in 24 hours!"
- Generic greetings – "Dear Customer" instead of your actual name.
- Suspicious links – hover over links before clicking; the visible text may say one thing but link elsewhere.
- Unexpected attachments – especially .exe, .zip, or macro-enabled Office files.
- Poor grammar/spelling – legitimate companies proofread their communications.





SPOTTING FAKE WEBSITES

- 01 Check the URL carefully – look for misspellings (amaz0n.com) or extra words/subdomains
- 02 No padlock icon / not HTTPS
- 03 Site asks for way more info than necessary for the action you're doing
- 04 Design looks slightly "off" – low-res logos, broken layout, inconsistent branding

SOCIAL ENGINEERING TACTICS

01

PRETEXTING

Attacker invents a fake identity or scenario to gain trust

02

AUTHORITY

Impersonates a boss, bank, or official to pressure action

04

FAMILIARITY

References real coworkers or events to seem legitimate

03

URGENCY & FEAR

Creates panic so victims act before thinking

05

BAITING

Offers something enticing to lure a click

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLES

Google & Facebook — \$100M+ Invoice Scam (2013–2015)

A Lithuanian man impersonated a hardware supplier both companies worked with, sending fake invoices over email. Both companies paid millions before the fraud was discovered. Shows how even large, security-conscious companies can fall for well-crafted business email compromise (BEC).

1

2016 US Election Campaign Email Breach

A campaign staffer received a fake "change your password" email disguised as a Google security alert. Clicking the link led to a fake login page that harvested credentials — a classic phishing + fake website combo, leading to a major data leak.

2

Sony Pictures Hack (2014)

Employees received phishing emails disguised as Apple ID verification requests. Once credentials were stolen, attackers used them to breach Sony's internal network, leading to one of the most damaging corporate breaches in history — leaked films, internal emails, and employee data.

3

BEST PRACTICES & TIPS

- » Verify the sender through a separate channel before acting on urgent requests
- » Never click links in unsolicited emails – go to the site directly by typing the URL
- » Enable multi-factor authentication (MFA) wherever possible
- » Keep software/browsers updated
- » Report suspicious emails to your IT/security team instead of just deleting them



QUICK QUIZ

- + WHAT'S A COMMON SIGN OF A PHISHING EMAIL?
- + SHOULD YOU CLICK A LINK TO "VERIFY" A SUSPICIOUS EMAIL?
- + WHAT IS PRETEXTING IN SOCIAL ENGINEERING?
- + WHAT PROTECTS YOU EVEN IF YOUR PASSWORD GETS STOLEN?
- + TRUE OR FALSE: A PROFESSIONAL-LOOKING EMAIL IS ALWAYS LEGITIMATE.



ANSWERS

- + WHAT'S A COMMON SIGN OF A PHISHING EMAIL?
→ Urgent/threatening language, mismatched sender address, generic greeting
- + SHOULD YOU CLICK A LINK TO "VERIFY" A SUSPICIOUS EMAIL?
→ No, go directly to the site by typing the URL yourself
- + WHAT IS PRETEXTING IN SOCIAL ENGINEERING?
→ Inventing a fake identity or scenario to gain someone's trust
- + WHAT PROTECTS YOU EVEN IF YOUR PASSWORD GETS STOLEN?
→ Multi-factor authentication (MFA)
- + TRUE OR FALSE: A PROFESSIONAL-LOOKING EMAIL IS ALWAYS LEGITIMATE.
→ False, polished design doesn't guarantee legitimacy

KEY TAKEAWAYS

PAUSE BEFORE YOU CLICK

urgency is a red flag, not a reason to rush

VERIFY INDEPENDENTLY

contact the sender through a separate, trusted channel if something feels off

ENABLE MFA EVERYWHERE YOU CAN

it's your safety net even if a password leaks

WHEN IN DOUBT, REPORT IT

don't just delete a suspicious email, flag it to your IT/security team so others can be warned too





**THANK
YOU!**